the kings exchanged emissaries and gifts. For instance, we have an inscription that tells us that Sri Mulan, the agent of the Srivijaya king of Sumatra, Malaya, had donated several lamp-stands to be installed at the Shiva temple in Nagapattinam.

The problem probably arose because the Cholas began to create direct trade links with the Song empire in China. Records show that Cholas and the Chinese exchanged a number of trade delegations in the early eleventh century. Indo–Chinese trade relations were not new. We know from Chinese sources that a large Indian merchant community had long been established in Guangzhou and that there were three Hindu temples functioning there. However, Song–Chola diplomacy appears to have led to a further boom in Indo–Chinese trade.

Unfortunately, the Srivijaya kings probably felt that their role as middlemen was being threatened by such direct linkages. They reacted by tightening controls and imposing heavy taxes on ships passing through the Straits of Malacca. A contemporary Arab text tells us that the Srivijaya kings were demanding a levy of 20,000 dinars to allow a Jewish-owned ship to continue to China.[21] This was a serious matter and the Cholas felt that they had to react. This led to a naval raid against Srivijaya in 1017 AD and then a more substantial expedition in 1025. These represent very rare examples of Indian military aggression outside of the subcontinent. The hostility was fortunately not long-lasting and a few decades later we find the Cholas and Srivijaya sending joint embassies to the Chinese.

I do not want to leave the reader with the impression that India’s relationship with South-East Asia was one of cultural, economic and, occasionally military, domination. Indian trade and civilization clearly had a very large impact on this part of the world, but it was a two-way flow. For instance, the university of Nalanda may have been founded by the Guptas, but its subsequent growth was partly due to the strong financial support extended by the Srivijaya kings. Moreover, South-East Asian kingdoms like Angkor, Majapahit and Champa took the Indian input and built on it. These people were not blindly copying Indian prototypes but innovating and indigenizing.